off anything remotely close to this. Our eyes meet like torches in the dark and we just stare at each other for a second.

'Look, eventually we'll get out,' I say. Monty nods, half-smiles, the kind of smile that forces itself on to your face against your will when confusion and fear are uncontainable. 'Let's just try our best.' He nods again, the smile giving way to a half-frown. It's not just about survival. There are equations at play. We are six runs behind with one wicket left, meaning that if we get ahead of them by enough, we might not allow them time to bat again and save the game that way. All that is a long way away, though. All it is worth reiterating is that this is clearly doomed. Let's try. David Lloyd on commentary, unknown to me, has just told the millions tuning in, 'If England needed a hero, here's Monty Panesar. What a monumental job him and James Anderson have to do for England.'

I am used to the feeling of being out there when we lose. I know how this pans out. I know that no one expects us to do this now. I actually prefer it out here to sitting in the dressing room. It's the nervous energy that's building towards me now that I hate, like waiting to be slapped in the face, knowing it's going to happen and just not knowing when. All sorts of superstitions have played out while I'm waiting, watching Paul Collingwood's rearguard. When I left to join him at the crease, there were people, eyes down, sitting in their lucky spot. There were others throwing a tennis ball against a wall as if in a trauma response. It's like no one believes that without divine intervention, I will get through it. And to be honest, I can't blame them.

For his first ball, Monty offers the face of his sponsorless bat in an earnest defensive shot to Peter Siddle. As the ball rushes past, the bat itself flickers left and right, as if it's a gate that has been swung open by a light breeze. The ball misses everything, including the stumps. Monty survives one. It's going to be a long 11.2 overs. There are two separate challenges from either end for both of us – Peter Siddle, bowling fast from one, and Nathan Hauritz, turning the ball out of five-day-old footmarks, from the other. Siddle is running in, spitting, angry, frenzied, his teeth looking strangely more sharpened, his necklace tight against his throat, like a sort of war decoration. Hauritz meanwhile just probes and probes, trying to make us guess the difference between playing and leaving. I hide my bat in fraction-of-a-second judgement calls when the ball spins, and, at other